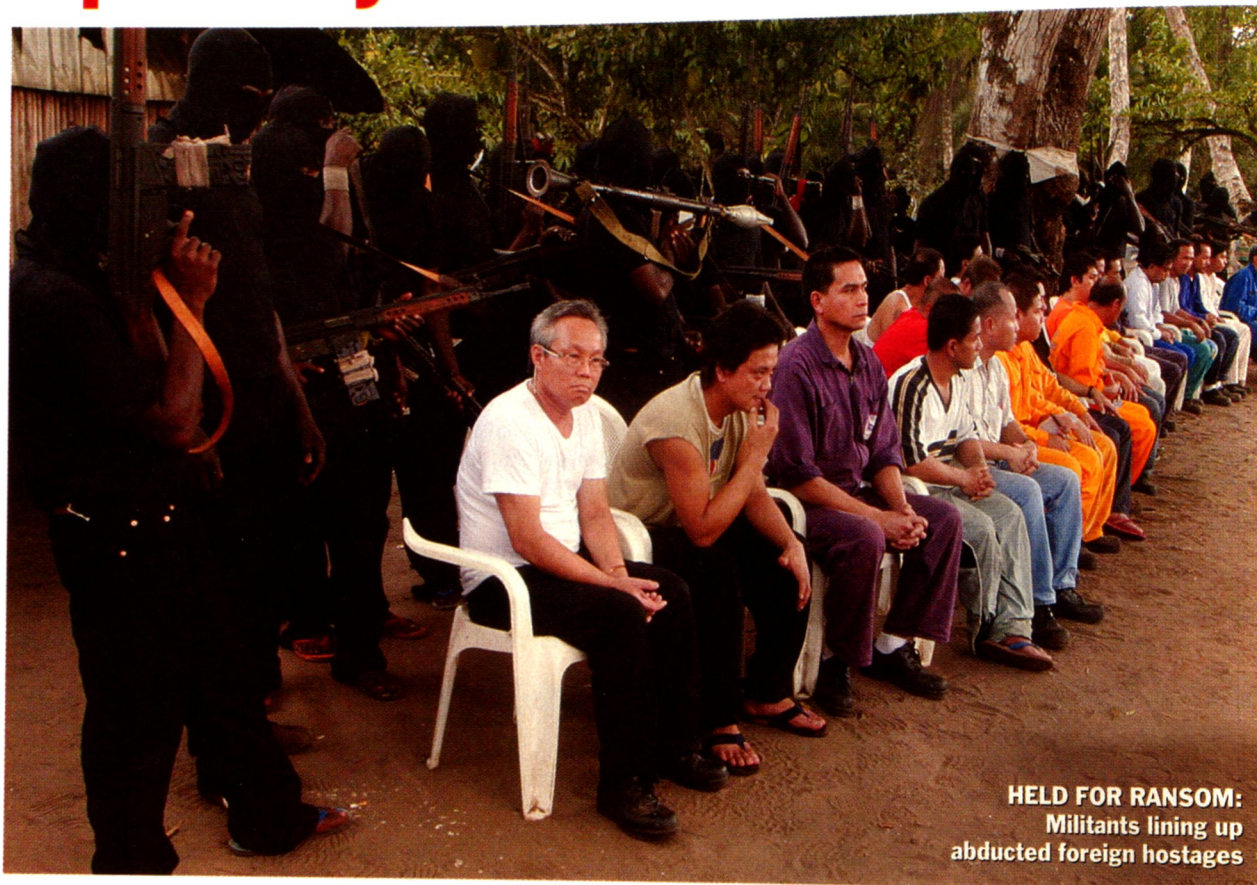
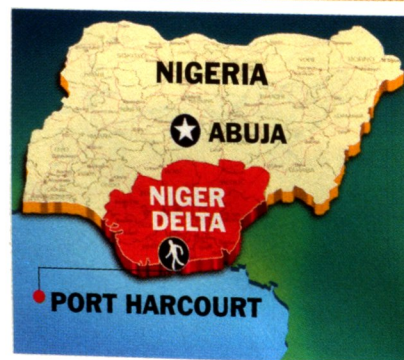




**HELD FOR RANSOM:**  
Militants lining up  
abducted foreign hostages

# LIVING ON THE EDGE

**A spate of kidnappings involving Indian professionals have left the Government worried about the fallout of the Nigerian situation**



■ By Saurabh Shukla

**I**n oil rich Nigeria, India's biggest trading partner in the African continent, there is a fast growing business that promises to be very lucrative. It's called kidnapping-for-ransom. Many Indian professionals living in the country, have experienced it first hand. Take the case of Arun Taneja, managing director of Eleme Petrochemicals, based in Port Hartcourt in the Niger delta. Taneja, and his nine other Indian colleagues along with their family members were kidnapped by 19 armed Nigerian rebels, who stormed their residential quarters in the dead of the night on May 19. They were made

to board a pickup, bundled on to three separate speedboats and then taken to an island. Spending 15 days in captivity was perhaps his worst ordeal after which he and his colleagues were taken back to the coast and were handed over to the Nigerian Government.

While the officials maintain that Taneja and his colleagues were set free in exchange for the release of the rebel leader Mujahid Dokubo Asari and no ransom was paid, sources say millions of dollars were paid as ransom. Soon after the incident, the company shut its operations and 250 Indians, including the top managers, returned to India.

The exodus is fast becoming a sore

point for both the countries. For India, which shares a trade of over \$6 billion (Rs 24,000 crore), with Nigeria, the alarm bells are ringing, as more than 35,000 Indians have been estimated to be living in that country. Besides, since India sources 20 per cent of its oil supplies from Nigeria, any major fallout may impact the overall Indian economy. Militant attacks have already led Nigeria to cut its oil production by 25 per cent. Moreover, at a time when Indian public sector companies, like the National Thermal Power Corporation, which has just signed a deal to establish a power plant in Nigeria, are planning to mark their presence in the region, the situation seems to be tough.